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CULTURE

Tamasha and the artist within

Eight years on from its release, a re-examination of what Imtiaz Ali's Tamasha actually says about theatre, storytelling, and the creative self — and why the 'trapped artist' metaphor it gave a generation of corporate workers has become so inescapable, and so misused.

BY MOULI SHARMA

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ABOUT

The Voice Express

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Ever since the 2015 Imtiaz Ali directorial, the perception of theatre in India has been altered to a metaphor. An unfulfilled wish of the corporate naukhar that he dreams of returning to after his early retirement. Here in 2023, I make an attempt to understand what makes theatre the voice of the trapped.

In *Tamasha*, baby Ved (Ranbir Kapoor) is mesmerized by the world of folktales and the charm of a Shimla storyteller. He reimagines mythological sagas in modern day and dreams of modelling the storyteller. But the quintessential *mujhe padhai samajh nahi aati* artsy child has a quintessential disapproving father. As he grows up, unhappy and unheard, he depends on a French island, a manic pixie dream girl and the Shimla storyteller to make sense of a confusing life. Until he realizes, kudos to the 'I'll fix him' Tara (Deepika Padukone) that he's not what he's been told he is.

Stories and storytelling are sought after as a means of escape from the monotony of the metropolitan- the tiring, the race, the pace. Theatre as an immersive art form of telling a tale includes both the performer and the audience. That misunderstood artist, that questions the way society works, inside a below-average product manager is given a purpose for that one-and-a-half-hour show.

Outside of what we already have, a job and a regular 9-5 life, we need a story, maybe more. Preferably more. This adventure of telling a tale and being a part of it is represented by theatre and storytellers in *Tamasha*. In the film we see theatre, not just as a means to express who we really are inside but also to maintain peace.

As Tara returns into Ved's life, he begins to lose his sense of distinction between the Don in him, the hero who does what he wants, and his shell, a pre-programmed robot. He loses the balance between his personalities and subsequently his job.

So used to being told what to do next, Ved seeks the Shimla storyteller to tell him what will happen next in his story, his life. But the old roadside storyteller rebukes his cowardice, unknowingly pushing him to take his life in his own hands.

*Finally, it was only a resonating story that helped Ved convince his father of his dream. It was a story that helped Ved meet Tara, make friends in a new town and ultimately pursue his passion. It was storytelling, theatre that connected the protagonist to his greater calling. *Tamasha* continues to be a cinephile's favourite and has convinced many to get into that theatre workshop.*

As one recites stories to an audience, there's hope to find oneself amongst all the characters played. Or just the tranquil of being someone other than whom you're expected to be.



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Mouli Sharma is a journalist, freelance illustrator, and writer from New Delhi, India. She is a published photojournalist & illustrator, having been featured in The Hindu College Gazette, & the quarterly Pink Disco. Mouli took over as the Editor of The Voice Express (<https://thevoiceexpress.github.io/e-mag/>) back in September 2023.

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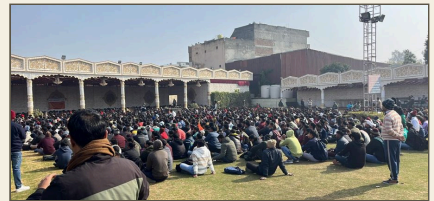
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